

UK POLITICAL INSTITUTIONS

1. The Monarchy – Buckingham - *The King reigns but does not rule*

- The UK is a **constitutional monarchy**.
 - The monarch, **King Charles III**, has **ceremonial** and symbolic duties.
 - Political power lies with **Parliament** and the **elected government**.
-

2. Parliament - Westminster

- The UK Parliament is **bicameral**, consisting of 2 houses:
 - **The House of Commons**: the upper house. 650 **elected MPs**
 - **The House of Lords**: the lower house. Around **800 appointed** or **hereditary peers**
 - **Main functions**:
 - Passes laws
 - Approves taxes and the budget
 - Scrutinises government actions
 - General elections are held **every 5 years**.
 - The current **Speaker of the House of Commons** is Sir Lindsay Hoyle (Labour).
 - A neutral figure elected by MPs.
 - Keeps order in debates, ensures parliamentary rules are followed, and represents Parliament externally.
 - Does not vote on laws except to break ties.
-

3. Government – Downing Street / 10 Downing Street / Number 10

The **Government** is Formed by the **majority party** in the House of Commons.

- The leader of that party becomes **Prime Minister** and appoints the **Cabinet**.
- The government is accountable to **Parliament** and may be removed by a **vote of no confidence**.

The **Shadow Government** is formed by the **main opposition party**

- Each Shadow Minister "mirrors" a government minister and critiques their policies (e.g., Shadow Chancellor, Shadow Home Secretary).
-

4. Current Political Situation (as of 2025)

- **The Prime Minister (PM)**: *Keir Starmer* (Labour Party)
 - **Governing Party**: *Labour* (elected with a majority in July 2024)
 - **The leader of the Opposition**: *Kemi Badenoch* (Conservative Party)
-

5. Main Political Parties in Parliament

Party	Approx. Seats	Notes
Labour	~411	In government
The Conservative party	~121	Official opposition
The Liberal Democrats	~72	Centrist, pro-European

Party	Approx. Seats	Notes
Reform UK	~5	Right-wing, populist
The Green Party	~4	Focuses on climate policies

6. The electoral system

- **The First Past the Post (FPTP)** is used for general elections.
 - The candidate with the most votes in each constituency becomes an MP.
 - This system tends to favour larger parties and can result in a government winning a majority without a majority of the national vote.

Some critics argue it under-represents smaller parties like the Greens or Reform UK.

7. The UK Supreme Court

- Established in **2009** as the UK's highest court.
 - Composed of **12 justices**.
 - Handles **final appeals** and **constitutional cases**, including **devolution issues**.
 - Independent from both Parliament and government.
-

8. Devolution

- The UK has **four nations: England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland**.
- Each (except England) has its own **devolved parliament or assembly**, with powers over areas such as:
 - Health
 - Education
 - Transport
 - Local laws

Names of the devolved legislatures:

- **Scotland:** *Scottish Parliament* (Holyrood)
 - **Wales:** *Senedd Cymru* (Welsh Parliament)
 - **Northern Ireland:** *Northern Ireland Assembly* (Stormont)
-

9. History of House of Lords Reform

- **Pre-1911:** The Lords could block any law.
- **Parliament Acts (1911 & 1949):**
 - Removed veto powers and limited the Lords' ability to delay legislation.
- **Life Peerages Act 1958:**
 - Allowed appointment of **life peers**, opening the Lords to people based on merit.
- **House of Lords Act 1999:**
 - Reduced **hereditary peers** to **92**, shifting to a mostly appointed chamber.
- **Ongoing Debate:**
 - Proposals for an elected second chamber continue, but no major reforms have passed since 1999.